A Crawl-Walk-Run Framework for Enterprise Artificial Intelligence (AI) Adoption

Ashwin Rangan

Enterprises Need a Staged Adoption Model

Artificial intelligence (AI) is now a board-level imperative, but most enterprises struggle with where to begin, how fast to move, and how to ensure value creation rather than experimentation for its own sake. The challenge is aligning culture, data maturity, risk posture, talent readiness, and business strategy into a coherent path that produces measurable outcomes.

A staged adoption model—**crawl, walk, run**—offers a disciplined way to build capability while reducing execution risk. It recognizes that enterprises cannot leap directly into transformative AI programs without first developing foundational literacy, operational guardrails, and confidence in the tooling. It also acknowledges that AI value creation follows a predictable new-technology adoption pattern of first gaining **"fearless" familiarity**, then seeking **margin expansion**, and finally exploring **new revenue growth**.

This model is particularly effective because it mirrors how enterprises learn. Early wins build confidence and trust. Successful cross-functional use cases build scale. Strategic use cases build competitive advantage. By sequencing adoption, organizations avoid the common pitfalls of AI programs of diffuse experimentation, unclear ROI, and misalignment between technical teams and business owners.

The crawl-walk-run model also aligns with responsible innovation principles. It allows enterprises to introduce governance, model risk management, and data quality controls early—before the organization becomes dependent on AI-driven workflows. In doing so, it ensures that AI adoption is not only fast, but safe, compliant, and sustainable.

Crawl: Build Literacy Through Targeted, Low-Risk Use Cases

The crawl phase is about learning the tooling, understanding the data, and building confidence. The goal is simply to develop competence and confidence, while simultaneously assessing the organization's cultural attitude and appetite for change.

Solve a simple, dense-data problem

Start with a problem that is bounded, well-understood, and rich in structured or semi-structured data. Examples include classifying inbound customer emails, prioritizing service tickets, extracting insights from financial or operational logs, and automating document summarization or compliance checks.

While the problem-space here may appear trivial, this class of problems allows teams to experiment with model selection, prompt engineering, agent orchestration, and semi-automated decisioning without operational risk.

They also help the enterprise understand where human-in-the-loop oversight is essential and where automation can be safely introduced.

Not least, it is an early indicator of the enterprise's culture and ability to overcome internal barriers to AI-enabled process orchestration.

Develop internal literacy, leading to visible, low-risk wins

The crawl phase is where teams learn how to evaluate model outputs, tune prompts and workflows, integrate AI agents into existing systems, measure accuracy, model drift and reliability, and establish basic governance and auditability.

This is also the right moment to introduce lightweight policies for basics, such as data access controls, model usage guidelines, and documentation standards. These become the scaffolding for more advanced governance later.

A successful crawl-phase project demonstrates that AI can solve real problems, not theoretical ones. It builds organizational trust and creates internal champions who understand both the potential and the limitations of the technology.

Walk: Scale to Margin Expansion

Once the enterprise has foundational literacy, it can move into the walk phase—by choosing a cross-functional, margin-expanding use case.

This phase focuses on operational efficiency at scale. Examples here could include optimizing supply chain forecasting across procurement, logistics, and finance; reducing claims processing time across underwriting, operations, and compliance; improving workforce scheduling across HR, operations, and finance; and enhancing fraud detection across risk, security, and customer operations.

These use cases require collaboration across departments, integration with multiple data sources, and more mature governance. They also produce measurable financial outcomes—cost reduction, cycle-time improvement, and potentially, measurable margin expansion, depending on the rigor with which the baseline has been established, and the rigor with which input variables and business outcomes get measured and reported.

The walk phase is where enterprises begin to treat AI as a strategic capability. It is also where model risk management, monitoring, and auditability become essential.

Finally—Run: Unlock new revenue through untapped data and mature tooling

The run phase is where AI becomes a growth engine. Enterprises use their now-familiar tooling, governance, and data pipelines to pursue new revenue opportunities, such as personalized product recommendations; dynamic pricing models; predictive customer lifetime value; new data-driven products or services; and AI-augmented sales and marketing engines.

This phase requires creativity, strategic alignment, and a willingness to rethink business models. It also requires the enterprise to treat data as an asset—curated, governed, and intentionally leveraged for innovation.

Why this model works

The crawl-walk-run framework succeeds because it builds capability before dependency, produces early wins that build trust, scales cross-functionally before scaling enterprise-wide, introduces governance early and strengthens it over time, aligns AI adoption with business value creation, and reduces risk while accelerating innovation.

Enterprises that follow this model avoid the trap of "AI tourism"—scattered pilots with no strategic coherence. Instead, they build a disciplined, repeatable, and value-driven AI capability that strengthens both operational performance and competitive positioning.